JOEL BERGER

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Platform Engineering & AI Executive

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Engineering executive with 26 years of experience leading technology organizations at Nationwide and Bread Financial. Founded and now leads Platform Enablement within Bread Financial's Platform Engineering organization, driving AI-powered software delivery (AIDLC) and modern engineering practices for a public financial services company. Has grown into progressively larger scope through both promotions and lateral moves across engineering domains spanning web, mobile, and platform functions, consistently delivering measurable results: stabilizing a major mainframe-to-cloud migration, cutting the defect backlog in half, and leading the AI development initiative now taking shape across the company.

CORE COMPETENCIES

Platform & DevSecOps: Platform Engineering, DevSecOps, CI/CD Pipelines, DORA Metrics, Infrastructure as Code, SDLC Governance

Cloud & Architecture: Microsoft Azure, Amazon Web Services (AWS), Cloud Native Architecture, System Integration

AI & Quality: AIDLC, Agentic AI, Generative AI, Quality Engineering, Test Automation, Test Data Management

Site Reliability & Observability: Monitoring & Alerting, Incident Response, MTTR Reduction

Leadership & Strategy: Executive Leadership, Technology Governance, Agile Methodologies, Digital Strategy, Vendor Management, Enterprise Thinking

Delivery Domains: Web Applications, Mobile Applications, RESTful APIs, Salesforce, IT Operations

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Bread Financial | Columbus, Ohio

August 2016 - Present

Senior Director, Platform Engineering | Platform Enablement *September 2024 - Present*

Established Bread Financial's Platform Engineering function in 2024, building it from a 3-team pilot into a lasting organization; led the Platform Enablement team within it.

- Founded and led Bread Financial's AI-driven software development lifecycle (AIDLC) initiative: set the vision and roadmap, built a cross-functional team spanning engineering, risk, cyber, and architecture, and delivered the company's first working proof of concept.
- Directed GenAI-powered Quality Engineering upgrades, including automated test case generation, tagging, and selective execution; launched a Test Data Management portal that processes hundreds of requests per month.
- Reduced the enterprise production defect backlog 51% and the defect injection rate 18% year over year through DevSecOps, Quality Engineering, and GenAI process and technology improvements.
- Managed Bread Financial's SDLC processes and standards; served as SDLC lead for regulatory examinations and streamlined governing policies and standards to reflect modern software engineering practices.
- Modernized CI/CD pipelines, enabling immutable proactive controls and automated governance, and replaced biweekly releases with on-demand deployments, improving enterprise delivery confidence.

Senior Director, Engineering | Servicing Engineering *September 2022 - September 2024*

Promoted from Director, Engineering to Senior Director, Engineering within the same team in November 2023.

- Built and led the Customer/Account engineering domain, supporting the Azure-based RESTful APIs behind Bread Financial's front-end servicing applications.
- Stabilized and operationalized systems following the company's largest migration of credit card processing off a mainframe platform to Fiserv and Microsoft Azure; led the ongoing technical relationship with Fiserv following the conversion.
- Reduced Fiserv transaction volume 20-25% by implementing API caching and circuit breaker patterns, enabling front-end servicing applications to consistently exceed availability targets.
- Drove additional availability gains through blue-green deployments, horizontal scaling, availability zones, and database connection pool optimization.

- Retired more than 125 underutilized servers and delivered $1.5M+ in projected annual savings through an evergreen API optimization program.
- Established end-to-end monitoring and alerting between Azure and ServiceNow, automating the incident management process and building dashboards that improved MTTR and customer experience.

Director, Engineering | Digital Technology and Enterprise Integration *August 2016 - September 2022*

Promoted from Senior Manager, Applications to Director, Engineering in April 2021.

- Expanded leadership scope from an $8M Salesforce and Mobile applications portfolio of 56 associates to the company's full Digital Technology Office, spanning Web, Mobile, and Salesforce engineering.
- Doubled mobile application adoption in 2 years while cutting go-to-market time from 7 months to 7 weeks; reduced the mobile defect backlog 73% in 1 year.
- Directed digital delivery for the NFL and AAA partner launches; led the digital build of the company's first card program on the American Express network.
- Led the technical delivery of BreadFinancial.com and NFLExtraPoints.com on a new Adobe Experience Manager platform, anchoring the company's brand transformation.
- Delivered the Account Center Redesign, Universal Authentication, and Mobile First programs, driving measurable gains in registration success, credit line increases, and account enrollment.
- Led IT delivery of PartnerPortal, the company's Salesforce-based brand partner platform, growing adoption to over 100 active brands.

Nationwide | Columbus, Ohio

May 2000 - August 2016

Manager, IT Application Development | Direct Growth Solutions *August 2012 - August 2016*

- Led a $7.6M Identity Management and Mobile applications portfolio across 2 agile teams and 32 associates.
- Spearheaded a $3.5M multi-factor authentication rollout that strengthened security for 1.5M+ online accounts.
- Directed a responsive redesign of Nationwide.com, growing online accounts and site traffic 25% in the year after launch.
- Built a university hiring partnership with Bowling Green State University that became a company standard, producing 40+ interns and full-time hires.
- Cut team defects 56% in 6 months; team earned 2 continuous improvement awards.

Manager, IT Application Development | Nationwide Financial Network *January 2009 - August 2012*

- Managed a $1.68M application portfolio and a team of 10 developers supporting web and mainframe systems.
- Led the transition of broker-dealer application support from a legacy East Coast team to a newly built local team.
- Led strategic elimination of the independent producer sales channel, reducing long-term operating costs.

Programmer Analyst, Specialist, and Consultant, IT Architecture | Retirement Plans *May 2000 - January 2009*

Progressed through 3 roles over 9 years, supporting Nationwide's retirement plans technology.

EDUCATION & EXECUTIVE PROGRAMS

Master of Science, Computer Science, Bowling Green State University, 2000

Bachelor of Science, Computer Science, Bowling Green State University, 1998

Advanced AI Leadership, Enterprise AI Leadership Series, CTO Forum, 2026

AWARDS & SPEAKING ENGAGEMENTS

Awards

- Bread Financial 2023 Leadership Excellence Award, January 2024
- Bread Financial CX Hero, October 2023

Speaking & Media

- Guest, Harness: "How Bread Financial Eliminated 2 A.M. Software Releases," video conversation, October 2026
- Panelist, Harness {unscripted}: "The Work Nobody Sees: Where Transformation Actually Happens," September 2026
- Speaker, Harness {unscripted}: "Shipping Smarter: Bread Financial's Journey to Release Independence," August 2025